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THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telcon with Carlos Andres Perez of Venezuela
on April 9, 1992 (U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Carlos Andres Perez, President of Venezuela
Interpreter: Stephanie Van Reigersberg
Notetaker: William Pryce and Robert Morley

DATE, TIME April 9, 1992, 11:24 a.m. - 11:42 a.m. DST
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

The President: Hello CAP, how are you? (U)

President Perez: Hello, I am delighted to hear your voice. (U)

The President: You don't sound very good. Your voice is gone.
Do you have laryngitis? (U)

President Perez: Yes, I have laryngitis, and it is difficult for
me to speak plainly. I wanted to talk especially about Peru, but
first, I should tell you everything here is going well for me and
for Venezuela. The situation is better. Today, we restored
constitutional guarantees. (U)

President Bush: I am so glad to hear that, I think of you often.
(U)

President Perez: But let's talk about the grave situation in
Peru. (U)

The President: Yes. (U)

President Perez: We have to make an effort to find a way out for
President Fujimori. Tomorrow the Rio Group meets in Washington,
and I think we could name a Committee of Foreign Ministers to go
down to Peru and talk to Fujimori, discuss a way out for him, and
to suggest that the Vice President (of Peru?) convoke early
elections. I am afraid that what Fujimori is doing could extend
to other countries. (U)

President Bush: Oh, my God. (U)

President Perez: Yes. We have to find a way to exert pressure
to get out of the current situation. (U)

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President Bush: Let me give our views, because we view this situation with the same degree of severity and urgency as you do. We are reviewing all our assistance programs and suspending new assistance programs. We need to work together to redress the situation as soon as possible. We need to make Fujimori understand that suspending democracy is not the way to solve the problems of Peru. But I understood that it will be the OAS meeting on Monday, not the Rio Group on Friday in Washington that was sending a mission to Peru. Is the Rio Group meeting here on Friday? (U)

President Perez: That's right. (U)

President Bush: Perhaps the OAS could send a high-level mission with the Secretary General to Peru to evaluate the situation and get a dialogue going between the various political factions on a return to democracy. That was one thought we had. On that one, it may be that you could use your influence, if you think you still have any, with Garcia and others to get them talking before they become frozen in their positions. We need to get them all in a substantive dialogue before this happens. We agree that the Rio Group can play a useful role, but it should not be a substitute for OAS action, given the legal character and mandate of the OAS. (U)

President Perez: Maybe I wasn't all that clear. What I meant to say was the Rio Group was going to meet in Washington on Friday. They would present the OAS with the idea of a mission to Peru. (U)

President Bush: Ok, we are together on this. Our thinking is that this is the next step and offers the best hope for getting things moving. But I have a question. Why do you think that Fujimori decided to do this at this time? I don't want to keep you talking too long, but I would like your views on this. (U)

President Perez: (At this point, President Perez had difficulty talking and we couldn't understand his next remarks. Beatrice Rangel explained that President Perez thought that the military in Peru had forced Fujimori to adopt the role he has taken. Perez had tried to talk to Fujimori Sunday night, but the military would not connect him with President Fujimori.) (U)

President Bush: It sounds like we are on the same wave length on Peru. We will stay in touch. You are a very important voice for democracy in the hemisphere. We are prepared to work with you to see how we can help restore democracy in Peru. (U)

President Perez: Thank you. Now we should talk about Haiti. What can we do to break the deadlock in Haiti? (U)

President Bush: We look on you as the expert, but here are a couple of ideas we have. We still feel the deal brokered by the OAS is the best alternative for a peaceful return of democracy and eventually Aristide's return. Now the opponents of the agreement believe they have successfully survived the embargo and

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don't need to compromise. We need to convince them that is not right. We are looking at ways up here to tighten the embargo, freeze Haitian assets and deny port facilities to ships that have traded with Haiti. We are examining all possibilities. Unfortunately Bazin, otherwise a good person, right now appears to be among those blocking implementation of the agreement. By doing this, he is discouraging the return of democracy and contributing to economic difficulties. It might be worth a call from you to him to try to persuade him to support the agreement. I understand Balaguer talked to him, but maybe you can do so too when you get your voice back. (U)

President Perez: I agree. But it is necessary to take stronger measures very soon as far as the embargo is concerned. (U)

President Bush: I see. We'll speed up our deliberations and see what we can do from this end. But I think it would be worth it for you to talk to Bazin. Are you going to do that? (U)

President Perez: Yes, I will do that. (U)

President Bush: We need to stay in touch on this issue. It is a tough situation for us. The refugees problem makes it especially difficult and unpopular for us. We want to see if we can't get the agreement implemented. We want a solution as quickly as possible, and want to stay in touch with you. (U)

President Perez: Very good. I want to send a big abrazo to you and wish you a successful campaign. (U)

President Bush: Yes, well, it is a difficult and ugly process up here. But I think I am going to win. The economy is improving. The big thing, however, is that things are improving for you in Venezuela. That is really good news. Stay in touch. A big abrazo. (U)

President Perez: Ok. Good By. (U)

--- End of Conversation ---

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